

have spent two decades telling Indian athletes that food is not fuel you throw in at the last minute. It is strategy, planned months out, measured to the gram. So forgive me if I watched Norway's World Cup run with a nutritionist's quiet satisfaction and a fan's open envy.

By now you have seen the headlines. Norway flew three chefs and roughly one tonne (more than 1,000 kg) of food, including Norwegian salmon and trout, plus their beloved brown cheese, to a team camp in North Carolina. The internet did what the internet does and decided this meant the Norwegians were too snobbish to eat American food. That story is nonsense, and their own chef said as much. The point was never distrust. It was consistency. The players know exactly what lands on their plate, cooked exactly the way their bodies expect, so that nothing about the food changes even when the country, the climate and the pressure all do. They still sourced their oranges locally. This was not some anti-American sulk. It was control, and control is really the whole game.

Take Erling Haaland, the tournament's cyborg-in-chief, though I want to be clear he is the example here, not the miracle. Yes, he eats organ meats, sleeps with an Oura ring, wears blue-light glasses before bed, chases morning sunlight, sits in ice baths and blends a green potion of milk, spinach and kale. Some of it I would gently argue with. His fondness for raw milk is a real health risk that no serious nutritionist would sign off on, and I would tell him so to his face. But strip away the theatre and what remains is a philosophy. Every variable he can control, he controls. Sleep, light, recovery, digestion, timing. He is not chasing one magic food. He is chasing a hundred small edges that add up.

Here is the part that should bother us. Haaland is not some lone

freak in that dressing room. He is the culture. Norway did not build one machine and cross its fingers. It built a setup where flying its own kitchen across an ocean is treated as normal, obvious, barely worth a mention. Australia did the same thing. So did England. For serious sporting nations, this level of preparation has quietly become the price of entry, and nobody over there thinks it is extravagant. It is simply the cost of turning up to actually win something. Back home, we are still arguing about whether a full-time nutritionist is worth the fee, as if world-class results were supposed to arrive on a budget of hope.

Now look at India, and try not to wince. We treat sports nutrition as a luxury item, something you bolt on if there is money left over, which there never is. Our cricketers, in fairness, are looked after. The Men in Blue travel with dietitians and physios and want for nothing. But cricket is our one pampered child. Walk into almost any other discipline and the picture falls apart. At the Paris Olympics we came home with six medals and not a single gold, finishing 71st, from a country of 1.4 billion people. Six. We can send a spacecraft to the moon on a shoestring, but we cannot reliably tell a teenage boxer what to eat the night before a bout. And the problem starts young. In a country still fighting child malnutrition, plenty of our future athletes are underfed long before anyone hands them a national jersey.

I am not exaggerating for effect. In large parts of our system there is no nutritionist at all. The coach writes the diet because the coach is the one standing there. Our hockey players once prepared for an Olympics eating at a training centre while, in the same country, IPL cricketers lived in five-star hotels with menus built around their macros. The global sports nutrition industry is worth somewhere around \$25 billion. India's share of that is barely \$1

billion to \$1.5 billion. That gap is not a rounding error. That gap is the medals table.

I want to be careful here, because I am an Indian and I love this system enough to be angry at it. I am not pointing at any one official or any one federation. I am pointing at a mindset. The old, stubborn belief that talent alone will carry us, that our athletes should feel lucky to get a jersey and sort out dinner on their own. We produce staggering raw ability and then hand it a plate of guesswork. Norway takes fairly ordinary talent and multiplies it with obsessive preparation. We take extraordinary talent and let neglect quietly eat away at it.

None of this needs Norwegian money. It needs Norwegian seriousness. A qualified nutritionist is a rounding error next to what we already spend on infrastructure that photographs beautifully and performs poorly. A properly fed athlete recovers faster, trains longer, breaks down less often and peaks on the right day. This is not exotic science. It is the most reliable, least glamorous investment in all of sport, and we keep skipping it precisely because it does not come with a ribbon to cut.

So here is my ask, and I make it as someone who has fed champions and watched near-champions fall short for want of a plan. Fund the boring stuff. Put a nutritionist beside every national squad, in every discipline, not just the one that fills stadiums. Treat food as performance, not hospitality.

Because the World Cup handed us an uncomfortable lesson. Norway did not out-talent the world. It out-prepared it. And until we decide that what our athletes eat is a matter of strategy rather than an afterthought, we will keep producing brilliant, hungry, under-fuelled sportspeople, then wondering every four years why the medals keep going to countries that bothered to pack a chef.